

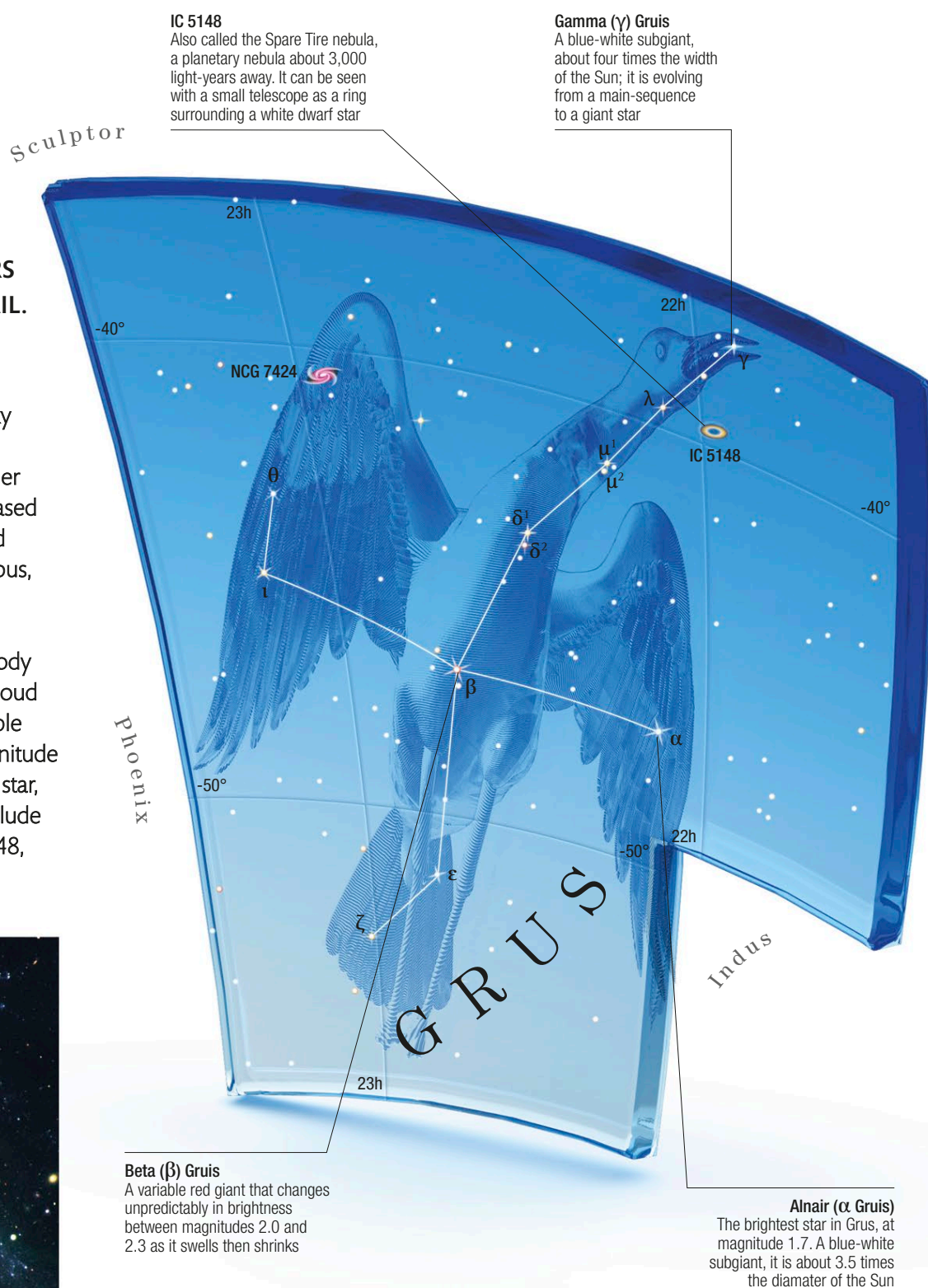
GRUS

THE CRANE

THIS CONSTELLATION WAS INTRODUCED TO THE SKY AT THE END OF THE 16TH CENTURY. ITS DISTINCTIVE FEATURE IS THE LINE OF STARS RUNNING FROM THE CRANE'S BEAK TO ITS TAIL.

Grus is one of several star patterns devised by Dutch navigators Pieter Dirkszoon Keyser and Frederick de Houtman, who made observations of the southern sky during an expedition to the East Indies in 1595. They passed on their observations to the Dutch cartographer Petrus Plancius, who created 12 new constellations based on those observations, all of which are still recognized today. (In addition to Grus, these constellations are Apus, Chamaeleon, Dorado, Hydrus, Indus, Musca, Pavo, Phoenix, Triangulum Australe, Tucana, and Volans.)

In Grus, the long line of stars through its neck and body can be extended southward to the Small Magellanic Cloud in Tucana. Lying within its neck is the naked-eye double Delta Gruis, which consists of two giants: a yellow magnitude 4.0 star, 150 light-years away; and a red magnitude 4.1 star, 420 light-years away. Other notable objects in Grus include the galaxy NGC 7424 and the planetary nebula IC 5148, popularly called the Spare Tire Nebula.



NGC 7424

This galaxy is similar in diameter to the Milky Way—roughly 100,000 light-years—and is about 37 million light-years away. It is classed as an intermediate galaxy, a stage between a spiral and a barred spiral. Its loosely wound arms are dominated by young stars, making them appear blue; the pale orange color of its central ringlike structure indicates older stars.

The stars that form Grus were originally part of **Piscis Austrinus** until the end of the 16th century